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PREVIEW

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The Way and the self in the poetry of Su Shih (1037–1101)

Cheang, Alice Wen-Chuen, Ph.D.

Harvard University, 1991

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PREVIEW

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THE GRADUATE SCHOOL OF ARTS AND SCIENCES



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PREVIEW

The Way and the Self in the Poetry of Su Shih (1037-1101)

A thesis presented

by

Alice Wen-Chuen Cheang

to

The Department of East Asian Languages and Civilizations

in partial fulfillment of the requirements

for the degree of

Doctor of Philosophy

in the subject of

East Asian Languages and Civilizations

Harvard University

Cambridge, Massachusetts

October 1991

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PREVIEW

Abstract

This thesis examines the poetry of Su Shih as an integral part of his activity of pursuing the Way. Since for Su Shih the Way comes into existence in the individual act of interpretation, literature (wei-wen) too can be a way of being and of becoming (wei-jen), a way of embodying the Way. This is particularly true of the poetry that he composed during his life in exile, first in Huangchou (1080-4) and later in Huichou and Hainan Island (1094-1101), for it was in those periods when he was out of office that Su Shih found in his poetry an alternative expression of his Confucian commitment.

*To my parents
with love*

PREVIEW

Acknowledgements

This thesis has been so long in the making that I cannot begin to count all the debts of honor I have incurred since its inception. I should like, however, to thank the Danforth Foundation and the Whiting Fellowship in the Humanities for their generous support; the staff of the Harvard-Yenching Library for their courtesy and assistance; and Tak-sing Kam for beautifying my text with his calligraphy and incidentally enabling me to submit my work on time.

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My family and my husband Ted already know how I feel. I should like again to give them my love for sustaining me, in this as in other things, and for reminding me always of my importance and my absurdity.

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Chapter One: Introduction

The following is a poem not by Su Shih 蘇軾 but by his younger contemporary, protégé and friend Huang T'ing-chien 黃庭堅 (1045-1105), who, after Su Shih, is perhaps the best known of the Sung poets. In itself the poem is only a variation (albeit it a skilful one) on a much-exercised theme-- that of the man in office longing for the freedom of a life of retirement-- but as a genre piece it serves to illuminate, with rare clarity, some of the chief concerns of the poets of the middle and late Northern Sung periods.¹

PRESENTED IN JEST TO K'UNG I-FU ²

¹ I follow the periodization adopted in Yoshikawa Kojiro in his Soshi Gaisetsu, translated by Burton Watson as An Introduction to Sung Poetry, Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1967.

² Shan-ku shih chi-chu 山谷詩集注, Ssu-pu pei-yao edition, 6, 6a. I-fu is the tzu (informal name) of K'ung P'ing-chung 孔仲平, whose biography appears along with those of his more illustrious brothers, Wen-chung 文仲 and Wu-chung 武仲, in the Sung shih 宋史, Beijing: Chung-hua, 1977; chüan 344, p. 10931 ff. Kung P'ing-chung was Huang T'ing-chien's colleague in the Imperial Archives when this poem was written (1087).

No meat for Sir Quill-- you can tell by his looks;
 From Squire Sterling a letter-- "you are no friend of mine!"
 When the work of writing does not bring order to the world
 Is it any different from a cobweb strung with dew?
 From "collator" to "editor"-- constantly promoted--
 Capable as ever at carriage-boarding and "how-are-you-doing"s.
 Suddenly I remember rustic meals, shared on a monk's couch,
 And in dream follow the autumn geese as far as East Lake.

戲呈孔毅父
 管城子無食肉相
 孔方兄有絕交書
 文章功用不經世
 何異絲窠綴露珠
 校書著作頻詔除
 猶能上車問何如
 忽憶僧床同野飯
 夢隨秋雁到東湖

Kuan-ch'eng tzu (here, a Dickensian "Sir Quill", but literally, "the Lord of Pen Castle") is the hero of the Mao Ying Chuan 毛穎傳 "The Biography of Fur Tip", Han Yü's 韓愈, allegorical "Life of A Writing Brush."³ Here the personified writing brush has become a metonym for its owner, the scholar-official Huang T'ing-chien himself. A scholar-official who is not fated to go far, apparently, for he has not got the physiognomy of a man

³ Han Ch'ang-li wen-chi chiao-chu 韓昌黎文集校注, Hong Kong: Chung-hua Book Company, 1972; p. 325.

destined for greatness, which in the clichéd language of fortune-telling is referred to as a "flesh-eater's face".⁴ A man whose future holds no promise of heroic achievement (kung-ming) is by the same token unlikely to come into possession of the wealth (fu-kuei) that often accompanies it, so it is fitting that line two should complete the parallel by establishing that our scholar is also very poor. "Squire Sterling" loosely renders the personified figure of Money, named K'ung Fang (Mr. Square Hole-in-the-Middle) after the shape of old Chinese coins, someone with whom all sensible people are urged to "become intimate as with an elder brother."⁵ Huang T'ing-chien has, of course, managed to do just the opposite.

The opening couplet is a neatly antithetical way of telling us that the poet is not the sort of person to succeed in public life and hence not one suited to his present career in the civil service. He does not tell us why he is not: but others before him have done so, and he reminds us of what they said. The "letter to sever ties of friendship" (chüeh-chiao shu) in line 2 has a much more famous original in the one written in the fourth century by the eccentric poet-recluse Hsi K'ang to Shan T'ao.⁶ In this earlier letter Hsi K'ang explains the reasons for his reluctance to assume the government post for which Shan T'ao has tried to recommend him. With a devastatingly suave assumption of humility, he lists the many defects of character and appearance which would make him a bad candidate for a career in

⁴ Pan Ch'ao 班超, the great explorer of the Han Dynasty, was told that his was the fortune of a flying tiger which "devours flesh while on the wing." "Biography of Pan Ch'ao", Hou Han shu 後漢書, Beijing: Chung-hua, 1965; chüan 47, p. 1571.

⁵ The commentary refers us to Lu Pao 魯褒, Ch'ien-shen lun 錢神論 "Essay on the God of Money", in the Chin shu 晉書 (Jen Yüan).

⁶ Yü Shan Chü-yüan chüeh-chiao shu 與山陰源絕交書, Wen Hsüan 文選, Hong Kong: Shang-wu Press, 1973; ch. 43, p. 939-44.

government, but this pretended self-indictment of the politically innocent Hsi K'ang is in fact a scathing indictment of politically ambitious men like Shan T'ao. The document has been read ever since as a manifesto attacking the corruption of life in politics and exalting the virtues of a life of personal freedom. Now in Huang T'ing-chien's poem there seems to be an ironic inversion, so that the letter of dismissal comes from none other than that great symbol of worldliness, Money, and the recipient is the all too unworldly poet himself. But "Money" in Chinese is surnamed K'ung, and this just happens to be the family name of K'ung P'ing-chung, the friend and colleague to whom this poem is "playfully presented". The coincidence is too much not to be intentional. If Sir Quill stands for the emaciated scholar Huang T'ing-chien, then Squire Sterling is the counterpart of K'ung P'ing-chung, moneyed man of the world: by referring to Hsi K'ang's letter to Shan T'ao the poet is drawing an analogy between that famous alliance of opposites and his own relationship with his friend.

Here we should take note of the ambiguity in the verb yu 有. Line 2 in Chinese reads: "Brother K'ung has got a letter to cut off ties." This can mean either that there is (yu) such a letter from K'ung or that the letter has been sent to K'ung and is now in his possession (yu). We do not know the exact circumstances of the occasion for this poetic jest-- whether perhaps the poet is avenging an insult received or threatening to deliver one-- but in either case the effect is the same. In appearing to laugh at himself for not being a successful type, Huang T'ing-chien is really teasing his friend for being perhaps too much of one; and in seeming to castigate his own poverty and obscurity, he is in fact demonstrating that he, unlike K'ung P'ing-chung and others of his sort, cares neither for a place in the political scheme of things nor for the emoluments which attend upon the acquisition of such a place.

But the sarcasm is deliciously indirect. In no wise does the poet claim to be better than such men; he merely points out, with murderous tact, that he is not one of them.

Yet, for all his disaffection, here he is, very much a part of the bureaucratic structure; so there follows in the second and third couplets a description of what the life of a bureaucrat is like. For such a man as he, it is a life charged with bitter ironies. As a wen-jen 文人, a member of the literate class whose right to govern was originally founded on their ability to write, Huang T'ing-chien had since the beginning of his career been distinguished for his skill in wen-chang 文章, in writing; and yet the poem makes it abundantly clear that this gift of wen-chang has nothing to do with what is required of him in the civil service. For writing, intones the poet with the assumed voice of pedantic gravity, is something that can only be regarded as useless ("does not bring order to the world"), mere decorative frivolity ("no different from a cobweb bejewelled with dewdrops"); as an official one must spend one's days doing something else. Lines 5 and 6 refer to a Six Dynasties jingle which levelled popular criticism at the aristocratic morons who filled up positions in government not by merit but solely on the basis of their personal connexions. It goes something like this:

Board a carriage without stumbling
And to Collator you go a-bumbling;
Ask 'how are you doing?'
To Editor soon you'll be moving.⁷

⁷ From Yen-shih chia-hsün 顏氏家訓 | (The Family Precepts of Yen [T'ui-chih]), section on "Exhortation to Study", SPPY edition, 3, 1b.

上車不落則著作
體中何如則祕書

Huang T'ing-chien had in 1085 (Yuan-feng 8) entered the Imperial Archives as Collator and within a year (in 1087, Yuan-yu 2) risen to the next level of Assistant Editor; hence the allusion to the story associated with the names of these two offices. This, then, is what poor Sir Quill must do: he must put up his writing brush and, along with the sedulous careerists and self-serving sycophants who set the pace of life in politics, struggle for advancement through a series of bureaucratic routines which are devoid equally of content and significance, cultivating pretended devotion to a system of values that he finds abhorrent and-- he notes cynically-- with practice becoming quite proficient at it. The irony is, of course, that someone employed in the Imperial Archives is supposed to have been chosen on the basis of his talent for writing.

Here we have the portrait of a man with brilliant accomplishments as a writer, who says that he has little hope of success in political life but who nevertheless seems to be getting along rather well-- precisely because he is not using those accomplishments. Bedevilled as he is in his present circumstances, it is not surprising that Huang T'ing-chien should dream of an escape into an alternative way of life, one which is peaceful and unhurried and, most important of all, meaningful. With an abrupt shift in the final couplet, the tone of the poem changes from satirical to lyrical. The poet "suddenly remembers" a time in his past when he had the freedom to spend an occasional day visiting a friend at a nearby Buddhist monastery, and the thought sets him dreaming of some future time when he can look forward to

such a leisurely life after his retirement. "East Lake" is located near Huang's birthplace in Kiangsi and thus stands for the object of his homeward yearning. The sentiment is banal-- practically every Chinese official has composed poems on this same subject of the pastoral ideal as seen from within the tangled web of public affairs-- but Huang T'ing-chien has given it masterful expression here.

We are reminded of what another, earlier poet decided to do when he discovered himself in a similar situation. T'ao Ch'ien 陶潛 (365?-427?) of the Eastern Chin-- the poet laureate of "field and garden", of the joys of bucolic reclusion-- realized, in the middle of a term in office as magistrate, how what he was doing was "a compromise upon his principles" and how what he really longed to do was "to give up his post and return home". This he did almost immediately, having spent no more than eighty-odd days in office, and wrote a fu (rhapsody) called "The Return" 歸去來兮辭 to celebrate his awakening to a new life in the country.⁸ Huang T'ing-chien does not mention any decision concerning his retirement. With him the desire to "return" takes no more definite shape than a moment of wistful longing. There is no evinced motive behind this longing, be it simple disgust like Hsi K'ang's at the prospect of sullying his nature with political pettifoggery, or the nobler impulse of T'ao Ch'ien to follow the bidding of his inclinations and thereby to perfect his nature as he feels it was meant to be. But the sentiment is there, and the tradition of writing on the pastoral ideal which forms the background to the poem has invested it with a dignity that Huang T'ing-chien makes no overt attempt to claim for himself.

The images in the last two lines ("monk's couch", "rustic meals",

⁸ T'ao Yüan-ming chi 陶淵明集, collated and annotated by Lu Ch'in-li 逯欽立, Hong Kong: Chung-hua, 1987; p. 159.

"autumn geese", "east lake") all belong to a common stock of poetic clichés, only here, instead of seeming stale with overuse, they have regained some of their native purity from being thrown into relief against what has gone before. Coming after lines so dense with allusion, the uncluttered simplicity of the closing scene is vividly and immediately felt. The contrast is not simply the contrast between a peaceful life of seclusion and the busy commotion of an official's life, but that between a poetic world and a world which is fundamentally unpoetic-- or rather, *anti-poetic*-- in its values. One should not miss, however, the wonderful double-entendre in line seven, where the man who lacks the physiognomy of an eater of flesh (line one) and with whom money-- or those in quest of it-- can no longer be friends (line two) is transformed into one who wishes that he could share his food and lodging with those who have-- in a rather different context-- abnegated meat and money! Even in the middle of a lyrical moment, it seems, Huang T'ing-chien cannot resist having his bit of fun.

The theme of the civil servant in office wishing he were out was so well-worn by the time Huang T'ing-chien wrote his version as to require only the very barest of outlines. This is why the poem can be at once so obvious and so oblique. The poet does not so much state the theme as refer to it. He can assume that we know what he is going to say from our knowledge of hundreds of other poems which have said much the same thing, and so all he has to do is point us to them, using allusion to create a series of discrete images for which the reader will provide his own connexions, based upon the configurations already familiar to him. This is, of course, the basic mode of construction for any number of traditional Chinese poems. What is interesting about this particular poem is that, depending on how we choose to connect its images, the pattern that emerges can be highly ambiguous.

Indeed one might say that ambiguity is the essential quality of this poem. Consider its central metaphor.

When the work of writing does not bring order to the world

Is it any different from a cobweb strung with dew?

The phrase ching-shih 經世 ("to give order to the world") is found in the Chuang Tzu story about an imaginary Prince of Jen who fished with a colossal rod and five oxen for bait and succeeded in catching a fish so large that he was able to feed the whole empire with it. The moral of this, says the author, is that just as those who fish for small fry can never hope to catch such a big fish, so those who make a big show out of their little theories, in the hope of "catching" an official appointment, are a long way from getting at the Great Understanding. "Therefore, for such as do not know the style of the Prince of Jen, they are far from being able to join in giving order to the world."⁹ Here the poet suggests that those who pursue the practice of writing are—like the men whom Chuang Tzu excoriates for the narrowness of their scope and the littleness of their aims—incapable of participating in the grand scheme of governing the empire. The idea that the uses of literature are insufficient to the conduct of politics was one of the clichés in the political philosophy current in Huang T'ing-chien's time. Is Huang T'ing-chien then declaring his simple allegiance to this common opinion, or does he mean something else by framing his statement in the form of a question?

I have translated wen-chang as "writing" because that is its general and usual meaning: more specifically it is "prose writing", the kind of documentary prose which made up the bulk of a scholar-official's daily

⁹ Chuang Tzu 莊子, Chapter 26, Wai-wu 外物 "External Things", in Chuang-tzu chi-shih 莊子集釋, Beijing: Chung-hua, 1985; p. 925. Cf. Burton Watson, Chuang Tzu: Basic Writings, New York: Columbia University Press; 1964; p. 133.

workload. But wen-chang has a broader-- and older-- meaning, one which the poet has revived for us by invoking (albeit only in the negative) the solemn and archaic connexion between wen-chang and government. Originally denoting "patterns of colour,"¹⁰ wen-chang came in the writings of the pre-Ch'in philosophers to signify "patterns of culture", including ritual and music-- all the different manifestations of the civilizing impulse-- as well as the patterns by which men put these into words. As such wen-chang became the sum and expression of that collective effort of human creativity by which state and society are constituted.¹¹ Good wen-chang--that is, the patterns, including writing, which embody what is good-- are the instrument of good government, while good government is in turn reflected in the written record. This is the premise on which the "Great Preface" to the Shih Ching 詩經 or the Book of Poetry, based its prescriptions on how to read poetry.

This, then, was the function-- the kung-yung-- of wen-chang in the classical age. What is left now, in an age when not only was the theory of the usefulness of wen-chang regarded as obsolete, but there were those who considered it untrue even in theory? ¹² Far from being the grand pattern in

¹⁰ Chou Li 周禮 . Cited in Morohashi Tetsuji, Dai Kanwa Jiten 大漢和辭典, Vol. 5, p. 579.

¹¹ Thus Confucius said in praise of the ancient king Yao: "... Lofty indeed were the things he accomplished, resplendent the patterns (wen-chang) which he laid down." (Lun yü 論語 8,19)

¹² It is no coincidence that the controversy over the question of the practical value of wen or wen-chang should have originated at the end of the classical age and the beginning of the Han Dynasty, because it was around this time that the concept of wen as "pure literature" first arose. In the third century, while it was still possible for Ts'ao P'i (186-226) to write in his "Essay on Literature": "Literature is the grand enterprise which gives order to the state, a glorious achievement that will never perish" (Tien-lun lun-wen 典論論文 Wen Hsüan 52, p. 1128), Ts'ao Chih (192-232) and members of his following

which the sage-kings made manifest their virtue (te 德), a pattern made up of words is now no more significant than a pattern of dewdrops glistening on a cobweb.¹³ By this the poet seems to be saying that literature is transient where it ought to embrace unchanging principles, useless where it should have a practical application. But the image of the "cobweb strung with dew",

were criticizing literature as "the lesser Way". By the middle of the T'ang (mid-ninth century), the political and cultural significance of literature had come to be purely theoretical. There was a short-lived revival of the importance of wen in the political philosophy of the Han Yü (768-824) circle, its impact and extent much magnified in retrospect by Ou-yang Hsiu; Po Chü-i (772-846) and Yüan Chen (779-831) also laid great emphasis in their early work on the vitality of the connexion between poetry and politics, as witnessed in Po Chü-i's autobiographical account in the "Letter to Yüan Chen" (Po Chü-i chi 白居易集, Ku Hsüeh-chieh 顧學頤 ed., Beijing: Chung-hua; chüan 45, p. 959). In the Sung, Ou-yang Hsiu (1007-1072) and his followers-- among them Su Shih and Su Shih's protégés-- continued to espouse the political importance of wen, but against them were arrayed such eminent thinkers as Chang Tsai (1020-1077), Shao Yung (1011-1077) and the Ch'eng brothers (Ch'eng Hao: 1032-1085; Ch'eng I: 1033-1107), who held that literature was useful not in itself but only as a vehicle for Confucian philosophical truths. The split between the so-called wen-hsüeh 文學 and tao-hsüeh 道學 thinkers has been documented elsewhere. (See, for example, Peter K. Bol, Culture and the Way in Eleventh Century China, unpublished Ph.D. thesis, Princeton University, 1982; Chapter One.) The tao-hsüeh philosophers were, strictly speaking, not lacking in a fondness for literature. Shao Yung, for example, was an avid poet, but because of his views on what wen ought to be, his poetry has none of the dynamic, self-questioning quality which animates the best of the poems written by the Su Shih circle.

¹³ There is a mischievous pun in the use of the word chui 綴 in line four. The Tuan commentary to the Shuo-wen 說文 glosses chui as "to join together with silken thread", which is precisely its meaning here. (Morohashi, vol. 8, p. 1101) The same character, however, also appears in the compound chui-wen 綴文 "to put together writing," and chui-wen chih shih 綴文之士 "men who write" has been used specifically to denote staff writers in charge of compiling the dynastic history, that is, men who are similarly employed as Huang T'ing-chien himself. (ibid., p. 1102) But instead of stringing pearls of wisdom into deathless prose for the benefit of future generations, the poet suggests, here he is putting together words as impermanent as "pearls of dew."

while it bodies forth all that is airy and insubstantial, is also an image of great beauty. And it is the beauty-- the poetic-ness of this poetic image-- which strikes us first and foremost. The writing that speaks of such things as dewdrops on cobwebs and is itself like a dewdrop--that celebrates beauty and is itself beautiful-- is, of course, this lyric poem, this shih. It has no kung-yung, no application in the body politic: the poet composes it as a joke and his reader will read it for a laugh, just as one might give a moment's fleeting attention to a dewdrop before it vanishes in the sunlight. Or is this all?

Observe what happens at the end of the poem. While Huang T'ing-chien's bureaucratic body is still shuttling energetically though without conviction from department to department, his poet's soul has flown off with the autumn geese to the place of his dreams. One moment he is remembering his other life, the next he has entered into it-- in reverie, through the opening which the poem has made. He does not say, "I wish I could go there," but rather, "In my dreams I *am* going there, have gone there already." Already, while still in bondage, he can taste of freedom.

"Poetry means to speak one's intent" (shih yen chih 詩言志), "intent" being equated with "feeling" (ch'ing 情), or the state of one's heart or mind (hsin 心) when the feelings are aroused. This is the oldest etymology of the word shih and it finds its most famous elucidation in the Great Preface. "In the heart/mind it is intent; put forth in words it becomes poetry." (tsai hsin wei chih, fa yen wei shih 在心為志發言為詩).¹⁴ To give voice what is in one's heart, to say what one's mind is set upon -- this then is the poetic impulse. It is a theory of poetry which places its primary

¹⁴ Mao-shih chu-shu 毛詩注疏, SPPY ed., 1.1, 3a. Originally found in the Shun Tien of the Shang Shu 尚書 or Book of Documents, II, i, 5 as: "Poetry puts intent into words, song intones the words" 詩言志歌詠言, here repeated and elaborated.